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About 4,000 words

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## Exiologist Expedition

by Burt Burlington

I have seen the host star of this planet peeking between the icy mountains thirteen times now. I don't know how many days that is back home, but it feels like I've been here longer than a month. Calling them "days" would be an overstatement; the shy little red dwarf star barely shows over the horizon. Scarcely giving any warmth to this bare snowball the researchers back at the university dared to call a planet. I have been chasing that star for a long time now, traversing the deep never-treaded-snow fields of XI-3. My feet frozen and my muscles aching. It's been a while since I last saw the others. I don't know if they have frozen to death, starved to death, or been eaten by the still-undocumented species roaming the planet's mountains.

I miss my colleagues. I especially miss my colleague Payu. I have never travelled in complete loneliness like this. Payu and I always travelled together, he would always be there for me. We would venture through the deserts of Musandra Yorta, the jungles of Ya-Ye, and the oceans of Ki-32. He's helped me with my biggest exiological breakthroughs, while also

saving me in some quite hairy situations to get to said breakthroughs. And just like that fateful night when I lost him together with our comrades, a storm was crawling over the mountains up ahead.

Even though I missed my friend, I wouldn't mind missing the deep ominous growling roar that has been following me. Hearing it far behind me the past few days, desperately I have been trying to get away from it. Every day the thing seems to be the same distance away--if not closer--then that dreadful night at the station. I would use one of the camp's snowmobiles if the solar flare didn't fry all electronics. *That rotten good-for-nothing star!*

I would like to run further away from the unknown beast that has been following me for days on end, but I would waste my energy and most likely freeze to death in my exhaustion. The gravity on XI-3 was  $7.300 \text{ m/s}^2$  — lower than on earth — but the conditions felt heavy if not heavier due to the unforgiving harsh snowfall. *What even is the point, what am I even running towards?* It's a never-ending ball of snowy hills with freezing—or being eaten—as its only liberators.

Again, the thing roars behind me through the thick mist that surrounds us. It sounds a bit higher than before; *it's getting closer*. The storm encapsulates me. *How can this creature keep following me?* Does it have one of the most sophisticated vision organs I have ever seen? The mists are too thick, not even light can penetrate them, so that is not possible. *Does it smell me?* It's rare for animals living in these kinds of environments to have an above-average developed sense of smell, but it is plausible still. *Can it sense infrared in any way like the Bog Yog from Traton?* If so, it would experience the same complications with it only being able to find “fresh” prey, and not able to find sustenance from cadavers or cold-blooded creatures it can't find. At least, that is one of the factors why the Bog Yog went extinct. Maybe, and this would be the worst-case scenario, whatever it is that is tracking me for the

last few days, is smart.

ROAR!

My theory-crafting of the creature was cut short by it itself. The thick mist made it impossible to trace where the roar came from. I didn't know where it was. Nor did I know where to go. I had to guess. I gambled on my right. Oh, I ran as hard as I could. Blindly I ran through the thrashing storm. Scared that I might collide with the thing I was trying so desperately to avoid. Clawing away through the bone-chilling, face freezing storm. I might dry heave out of sheer exhaustion. But even in this deafening storm, I didn't dare make a sound. I had to keep my bodily reflexes under control and suppress them as hard as I could. Then I felt something, even more terrifying than a roar. I felt the foot of the thing land behind me on the ground. It was closer to me than ever before.

Yet I still couldn't see it. I stood still, curled up in a ball and didn't move. I was tired... I was so tired. Weeks I have been walking, without a goal, a marker, a finish line; no promise of an end to this wretched embodiment of death. I didn't want to move anymore. Even if I wanted too, I didn't think I could.

I could feel my body at war with my brain. My body throwing in the towel, while my brain was screaming from the side-lines.

I slowly closed my eyes. Took in my last deep breath of striking cold air and curled up into a tinier ball. Until I heard the roar again, but this time from much farther away. *Oh, did I miss that roar from far away!* My eyes shot open, adrenaline shooting through my veins. I pushed myself up and ran away from the roar. It could've been the same direction I originally came from. But should you have doubt when you are on a ball with no-way out?

That last thought sucked the adrenaline right out of my body. My body, again felt as heavy as stone. But I knew I couldn't give in. With all my strength, thrashing through the winds. Step. By. Step.... No. Rest.

The fog started to change colour from blue to white. Abstract shapes started to appear in the all-encompassing white curtain. I was close to a mountain, or a *cliff*. No saying whatever I was heading towards. But I knew whatever I was heading away from was much more sinister. Better to have a harrowing quick fall to my death than a harrowing slow one.

In the white mist I could see a dark dot start to appear. Just like those ancient projectors, the black void vibrated and was unsharp. As I came closer, a dark circle appeared before me in the white mist. I could hear howling noises come from the abyss. Finally, something other than the thrashing winds around me. I stepped into the void and the winds faded.

A cave. Shelter. Rest. I dragged my broken body deeper into the cave. I collapsed on the cold stone. When closing my eyes, I could see a lonely out of place snowmobile sitting in the corner of the dark blue cavern. Without the strength to open my eyes again, I dreamed of what this snowmobile could grant me.

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When I woke up, my will to live had re-entered my body. I was jubilant, not only because I get to find out if this snowmobile works or not. But mostly because whatever was out there, didn't find me in my vulnerableness in here. Still, with my bones aching, I made my way towards the snowmobile. *Are some of my colleagues here? Is there food? Does the snowmobile work? Was it safe here during the solar flare? Is the radio working?*

I haven't felt this excited since the time we found those Tingya-ye's in the planetary forests of Ya-Ye. Me and my fellow exiologists spent weeks rummaging through the towering damp jungle, dreaming we would hear a mating call, let alone see a glimpse of one. The heat made us pass out multiple times and being drenched with sweat and water was the norm. The chances of getting poisoned by plants, torqi's, and insects were high, while the chance of the antidote existing for these diseases were null. I can't remember how many times Payu and I had to help each other up during this expedition. Death was possible. We accepted it.

Which made it all that much more worthwhile when we saw those stunning Tingya-ye's graze the purple grasses of Ya-Ye. Payu was the first to point out how the small yellow Tingya-ye's, could graze in the fields undisturbedly, without being attacked by more fearsome predators. Yellow being such a rare colour in the jungles of Ya-Ye, Payu theorized that it had to be a case of aposematic colouration. And the mad genius was right, as usual. No animal dared to step close to the beast for fear of it being poisonous. Our hypothesis was that it could be a plausible defence mechanism for the species. It had the perfectly yellow colour of a 6000-degree star with blood red triangles on its slimy skin—the classic colour combination of noxious animals. Back at the university lab, Payu was proven right again when the Tingya-ye's blood test came back negative for poison.

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The warmth of the jungles of Ya-Ye faded when an icy shiver pulled me back to reality. I remembered I was in a dreary cave on a white deserted planet. With my blue hands, I turned on the ignition of the snowmobile. Nothing. I turned it again, stomping on the gas pedal. Nothing. I checked the cargo space under the seat. *Brilliant!* A red thermal blanket, with the crest of our university. Reading our motto under it; "Quava I Trox O Phennis"; "Ever in search for knowledge." *Not anymore, I am in*

*search of getting off this despicable snow globe!* With great excitement I had wrapped myself tightly in the cloak. My excitement grew even more when I saw that three bags of rations were hiding all snugly under the blanket. There was also a pocket radio in the cargo space. *If that actually work...* I thought. I picked it up and went to turn the dial, but I hesitated. I sighed and put the seat back on top of the compact cargo-hold. I sat the radio on top of the seat and looked at it, staring it into submission. This radio might be my only way out—without it, I was doomed. If it was broken, how could I fix it? I didn't have any tools. The only tools I have access to are rocks, which I luckily have plentiful. I was thinking of praying to a higher power, something ancient civilizations did or some animals I have studied through the years. *But to whom, or what?* I was completely uninstructed on this systematic study, nor was I instructed to survive the snow deserts of unknown planets. I had no god to pray to. Only luck. I had nothing to wait for. *This thing has to work. It just has to!* And as I extended my arm. It felt as if it was made of jelly. My shivering fingers wrapped around the knob. I twisted it. A high tone sang from the small speakers. I swallowed, and after that, a warm cloud of air escaped my mouth.

*There was hope.*

I knew the radio wouldn't work in this cave. If electromagnetic radiation from the solar flare can't go through the mountain, neither can radio signals. I would have to climb to the top of the mountain to ensure that the radio works optimally. But before that, I will spoil myself with one of the rations. It had already been two days since I ate the last of my food supply. While I was huddled up, sporting my institute's red blanket, I was preparing one of the three bags. Even though the chemistry isn't ground-breaking, I am still impressed how they came up with it. You just had to rip the “CO<sup>2</sup>” sticker from the back of the pack. The gas-water would then liquify. Then all you had to do is shake it and the chemicals inside

would become red hot, to 100 degrees Celsius I believe. All while not burning your hand because of a particular encasing, *amazing!* The magical packet would cook you a lovely and much needed stew. I picked “Algeon Chicken” from the three packets. I actually really enjoy the taste of the water-based chicken breed compared to my missing comrades. *My comrades... Who of my comrades' rations was I eating? Where there any survivors back at the station whom I deserted? Was Payu still alive?* As I sat in silence, ruminating through my thoughts and missing memories, of the times Payu and I went on excursions, and made breakthroughs in the field of Exiiology. The chance of Payu having survived the horror that XI-3 had to offer, was as bleak as the snow outside. Huddled up in this mountain that saved me, I decided to dub this mountain as; ‘Mount Payu’, in memory of my dear friend.

There was no time to lose. I have to send my help signal with the radio, and enough food to survive two to three days. That could be just enough for the rescue team to pick me up. I wrapped myself in my red incandescent blanket and was ready to face the harsh tundra again. Luckily the endless storm that terrorises the planet was not on this side of the hemisphere at this point in time.

When I was about to step outside the cave, I realized something. With my newfound red cape, I stick out as a bloody ripped out tooth between white teeth. Whatever that thing was that has been hunting and haunting me the last days, can see me from a mile away. But again, this is the first time I don't feel like I will lose fingers or toes to frostbite. After some thought, I had decided to go into the white expanse with my trusty cloak.

The storm was absent but the winds had stayed raw and cold. My face being punctured by millions miniscule needles of uncomfortableness. Climb venturing up the emotionally and physically tough Mount Payu. And as I looked over the mountainous region, I could see only snow and blue-grey stone. It could be deserted from any living organism, or

it could be booming with life. Plausible, yet unlikely. The only empirical evidence we gathered in our short-lived research at the station, was that of only a few white six-footed rabbit-like animals with purple eyes, and a kind of skin bag on its back. We locked the small critters in cages, we were planning to do tests on them. *How can they see? Are they intelligent?* and *What do they eat?* were questions the entire team had. I remember Payu being especially interested in what the creature's diet was because food was scarce on XI-3.

But when the solar flare hit the planet, and contaminated the electrical systems, all systems failed. The three hairy living things we found on this snowball, besides rocks and stones, escaped. And with the electricity shutting down, all of us were blind and freezing. And the planet had turned our cosy research station into an improvised freezer. That was when the roaring started. With the laser fence mechanism fried, and animals being curious what this metal blocked peculiar “cave” was, we knew it was just a question of ‘when’ the roaring animal made its way into the building. It had become a dark freezing death trap. I found it so frustratingly coincidental that when the solar flare wreaked havoc on the globe, the same time the unknown beast showed its presence in the way of its blustorous shout. I didn't want to find out how the two were correlated and neither did my team.

As all of us were packing and preparing our bags for the journey, to search for a safe cave to sit out till help would eventually come. A scream sounded. And with none of the ventilation, heating system, and laser fence to obscure the sound, the scream rushed all the way from the other side of the station. “It's here! It barged through the door!” one of my unfortunate colleagues screamed. In the darkness outside my door, I saw the professional adventurers guiding us through our research, run towards the noise, while the scientists like myself ran away from it.

“HELP!” an adult screamed.

I stood, frozen in my room, calculating what I needed to do.

“We need to evacuate!” instructed a female voice, which had to come from Xixi. That made my decision easier. I picked up my bag, strapped on my coat and ran away from the commotion. I could hear glass shatter and metal walls bending or even breaking. Screaming, male and female, filled the hallways. I knew retaliation would be impossible with our recently-useless electro-charged weapons. But who was I to make them feel repent for their bravery. While the beast was thrashing, roaring and terrorizing its way through the station, I exited on the other side.

With darkness around me and a storm to follow with it, I ran into the station's yard. I traced fresh snowmobile tracks from the inner garages of the station, to a black dot in the far distance. “A working snowmobile!” I was jubilant, but this didn't last long when I realized I wasn't the one escaping with it. Who was the coward that had hid the only working snowmobile for themselves? The egotistical bastard. As I stood there, hopelessly in the snow yard, I could hear the tearing of metal and people from inside. Instinctively and instantaneously, I ran after the soaring snowmobile, never to see my colleagues again.

Remembering, something came to me; *who's university cloak am wearing?* I remembered that professor's names were embroidered in them. I hid away from the winds in a small indentation in the walls of Mount Payu and sat down. I unwrapped myself from the warm cloak, and checked the name on the inside. “Payu”. *PAYU! My dear friend Payu! It was him whom escaped that dreadful cold night on that snowmobile. That coward. That Egotistical oath.* I don't know if it was the low oxygen concentration this high up in the mountains, or my searing anger that made the world spin.

I made it on the top of the mountain, which I from now on dub ‘Mount Coward’, in remembrance of my cowardly forgotten friend. The winds were cold but fair. While having to

fill my exhausted lungs with cool air, I had a chance to appreciate the landscape. All shades of white and blue danced between the clouds as far as my eyes could see. Clouds climbing and falling over the side of mountains as waterfalls. The contrasting shy red star peeking through the planets crown of mountains. The freezing hell hole was starting to become beautiful in a way. When I caught my breath, I immediately planted my ticket home into the ground in the form the radio. Still, with great terror running through my veins, I turned the dial, fearing it wouldn't function. *But it did!* All I could hear was a high tone with white noise and the windy planet's whisper.

"This is Trias, exiologist from Warrda University. I am stranded on the snowy tundra planet XI-3024315! I repeat, I am stranded on the snowy tundra planet XI-3024315. I will be at the Warrda Planet Research Station in two days. Send help quick for I am devoid of resources and food!"

Standing in front of the radio, waiting for a response. Just more uncertain rustling from the machine. "I repeat, I am stranded on the snowy tundra planet XI-3024315. Please help!"

I sat beside it, curled up in my bright red cloak. Thinking about how long the battery would persist. At that moment, the unknown, the thing that's been chasing me, filling the planet's atmosphere with its roars, showed its face to me. Its white hairy head was just over the edge and the beast was climbing up to me. I was frozen in position.

*"How did it find me?"*

*"Did he hear me?". Impossible I scoffed.*

*"Was it the radio?"*

No time for thinking.

A gaping mouth roared at me. The mouth seemed to have micro teeth as big as tips of knives. It had multiple jaws all the way down to its throat. Its pupilless blue eyes positioned under his head staring right at me. It was big enough to swallow me whole, and get ripped to shreds by the millions of teeth.

I did not know what to do. Where to go. The only thing I remembered was that I haven't moved a single inch in my red fluorescent robe... *But that's it! Aposematism!*

The beast set its fat foot armed with sharp claws on the top of the peak, and we stood face to face. The beast, charging me with all its muscle rushed at me with the power of a comet. Its mouth roaring and its claws spreading. *Batesian mimicry can't let me down now.*

When the beast was ten feet in front of me, its mouth closed. Its claws shot into the ground in front of itself, making it come to a grinding halt. The sheer air thrust that came over me was enough to blow me away. But I couldn't move an inch.

Standing on all six of its feet, the beast looked at me with its opaque eyes, in which I could see my own reflection.

The heat coming from its carrousel mouth fell down over me. I could see its blue eyes inspect my fiery red cloak.

I tried to breath slowly, but my chest gave away my stress. The beast roared inches away from my face. A high tone shot in my ears and it was the only thing I could hear.

Before I knew it, I was thrown aside on my side by the stupendously strong claws. My ribs hurt, and all I wanted to do is stay down. But I couldn't. I had to stand up. Quick. The beast clawed to me, towering over me.

I stood up as fast as I could, pain shooting through my entire torso. I couldn't. Give. An. Inch. I looked up at it. I decided to stand up. I was closer to its mouth than any living creature would ever want to. Close enough that I could see the jaws spinning around its

mouth, all in opposite directions from the one beside it. As an exiologist, I couldn't help myself and be fascinated by the beast. If a creature, or me instance, would touch any of those millions of micro-teeth, escape would be impossible, and you would only be dragged in deeper and deeper. The creature took a step back. I didn't know if this beast could experience emotions, but if I had to guess, it was furious.

It looked at me and I looked at it. Winds blowing between us without neither of us moving, as if we were just two massive mountains. It felt like an eternity that the beast was staring me down, and it probably was. Doubting to let me go or kill me.

The beast turned around, as if it was never interested in me. The big claws landing on the stones was still terrifying thrilling. But I couldn't let it know it, nor could I let it be known that I was relieved.

When the beast was fully turned around, it revealed a giant transparent sack was strapped to its back. It was made of a wall of plasma membrane which looked like a single layer of animal cells. Its purple veins correlated between the skin sack. It was even more horrifying than the beast looked from the front. My stomach turned when I saw what was behind that thin layer of membrane. Inside the skin bag was Payu, molten with the inner flesh of the beast. The purple flesh wall inside had almost fully digested my dear friend. And... I don't know if I dare to remember this correctly, but I could see Payu's eyes looking at me, filled with despair and anguish.